

the Civil War sabers were rarely more than decorative; Southern cavalry often did not carry them at all. Pistols, such as Colt or Remington revolvers, were the standard weapons. Union troopers were issued carbines—typically the Sharps model—and later in the war sometimes with the repeater Spencer rifle. Southern units, unable to match this level of weaponry, often relied on infantry rifled muskets or shotguns.



Sheridan at the Battle of Winchester

One of the rare saber charges of the war was conducted by two of Sheridan's divisions at Winchester in the Shenandoah Valley on September 19, 1864. Even at this battle, however, Union cavalry did the most damage with their carbines.